



Pictures have both raised money from the stock market to support sensible cinema. Their styles couldn't be more dissimilar. While Nandy, sporting ripped jeans and a T-shirt that reads "The more I look within, the less I find", can take some credit for the Rs 2-crore multiplex movie which has a limited release backed by efficient marketing (think *Jhankaar Beats* in 2003), PVR's low-key Ajay Bijli powered Aamir Khan's *Taare Zameen Par* from a Rs 25-crore movie about child care and education into a blockbuster. Listing has made Bollywood more adventurous. Take Subhash Ghai, who created Mukta Searchlight to spark a sleeper hit like Nagesh Kukunoor's *Iqbal*, and directed an earnest Rs 7.5-crore film like *Black and White*.

A-TEAMS: (Clockwise from left) Eros's Kishore Lulla; Rakeysh Mehra with UTV's Ronnie Screwvala; Sandeep Bhargava of Indian Films with Abbas-Mastan

But while Nandy and Rajat Kapoor can rejoice about reviving Kumar Shahani's long-stalled *Anna Karenina*, UTV, Indian Films and Eros are more concerned about being able to release at least 20 movies a year. Their strategy is simple. Through a combination of their own independent productions, acquisitions and co-productions, they hope to keep investors impressed. Sometimes, they get lucky. Take Indian Films. When they bought *Jab We Met*, produced by Shree Ashtavinayak at a budget of Rs 15 crore, for Rs 21 crore plus a commitment of Rs 3 crore for publicity, industry veterans couldn't help scoffing. A movie directed by a till then little-

known Imtiaz Ali starring the kiss-of-death pair Shahid Kapur and Kareena Kapoor looked like a non-starter. But not only has the studio made Rs 60 crore just from the theatrical run in India and the UK, but it has also pocketed Rs 20 crore from satellite rights.

The risks don't always pay off. Eros, for instance, paid Rs 45 crore for *Salaam-e-Ishq* but was disappointed with the box-office results. "I told the producers to trim the length but they didn't listen," says Lulla. Paying good money for bad product is an unenviable position to be in but for these studios, in the first flush of showing numbers to their public, it's a necessary evil.

"Long-term relationships with talent is our biggest challenge." RONNIE SCREWVALA
CO-FOUNDER, UTV

deal with UTV for Rs 4 crore.

The scale has magnified. Last year, when Eros bought the world rights of *Om Shanti Om* from Shah Rukh Khan's Red Chillies Entertainment for Rs 73 crore, it looked like the final frontier had been crossed. This year just the domestic theatrical rights of *Ghajini* have been sold for Rs 53 crore—all the rights put together add up to Rs 93 crore, with the highest bid for worldwide satellite rights at Rs 21 crore. Last fortnight when *Race* released worldwide with 1,600 prints, the industry rejoiced at its new proportions. But already *Ghajini*, for which shooting will go on till May, and *Singh is Kinng*, which has days in Egypt left, are planning to release

across 2,000 screens worldwide.

It's a function of growth in attendance, rise in the number of exhibition centres and simply, much better marketing. Take an example. Last year, *Saawariya* and *Om Shanti Om* released on the same day, each threatening to undercut the other's business. It didn't happen. While the Rs 36-crore *Saawariya* made Rs 57 crore, the Rs 25-crore *Om Shanti Om* made Rs 110 crore. It is no surprise. Multiplexes, with their higher priced tickets, are booming—while 33 were added in 2006, 41 were built in 2007.

It's a great time to be the "talent". Neil Nitin Mukesh, star of *Johnny Gaddar*, a Rs 10-crore film that few

managed to watch, is demanding Rs 1.5 crore. Sagar Bellary, who made his first film, *Bheja Fry*, for Rs 60 lakh, which went on to make Rs 12 crore at the box-office is making his next film, *Kachcha Limboo*, with Sahara at a budget of Rs 5 crore. Madhur Bhandarkar who thought he had arrived when he could make both *Corporate* and *Traffic Signal* for Rs 3.5 crore each is now helming the Rs 18-crore *Fashion* for UTV. Even directors who've had mixed box-office results have their hands full. Sujoy Ghosh whose second film *Home Delivery* was a spectacular failure, is now directing *Alladin* with a budget of Rs 60 crore for Eros, while Vivek Agnihotri, the director of the middling *Dhan Dhan Dhan*